



Shakespeare or Romeo in Love?

By Chris Jose

Film Review¹: Shakespeare in Love (1998)

*****Warning: Spoilers Ahead*****

¹ Citations: Madden, John. Shakespeare in Love. Miramax, 1998

In John Madden's film *Shakespeare in Love* (1998), it showcases the rise and early career of William Shakespeare. The film centers on a young Will Shakespeare played by Joseph Fiennes, plagued by writer's block. Shakespeare's struggles are displayed as he writes *Romeo and Ethel*, the Pirate's daughter. As someone who read *Romeo and Juliet* prior to watching this film, I found many references from the play as the film progressed. The film has Viola de Lesseps (Gwyneth Paltrow), an aristocrat who enjoys theater and acting so much that she disguises herself as a man named Thomas Kent to audition for Shakespeare up and coming new play. With Shakespeare in love (see what I did there!), their romance soon mirrors the plot of *Romeo and Juliet*.

The film takes place during the Elizabethan era, in London, England. The film enlists Geoffrey Rush as money-strapped theater owner Philip Henslowe, Colin Firth as Viola's *down bad* fiancé Lord Wessex, and Ben Affleck (also Bruce Wayne) as the famous actor Ned Alleyn. Judi Dench acts as Queen Elizabeth I, highlighting the Elizabethan era's rise in theater and literature. I found the film to be humorous with a mix of historical references especially when Queen Elizabeth I spoke towards Lord Wessex when she gave her opinion towards his and Viola's relationship.

What made *Shakespeare in Love* so entertaining for me is its intersectionality of history and fiction. By highlighting that Shakespeare's own life shaped his greatest romance, the film personalizes the playwright, humanizing him as someone who scrambles to pay debts and searches desperately for inspiration. Whenever I hear of William Shakespeare, it is of high regard and in the G.O.A.T conversation of writers so seeing this film showcase his struggles made it more entertaining for me. The humble beginnings from the trenches and rise to the top help ground the film's romanticized setting. The romanticized setting is influenced by the introduction

of Viola's desire to become an actor which leads to conflict in the plot. The historical context is reflecting the period's rule where only men could appear onstage. Again, this was 400ish years ago and I still find it hard to believe that it was illegal for women to become actors but yes, that is how the world functioned back then. The world has come so far! Hence, seeing Viola risk following her passion to become an actor, had me rooting for her.

At times, I found the portrayal of Shakespeare as a struggling writer slightly overblown, even though I appreciated the twist of seeing a world-famous playwright grapple with self-doubt. The film emphasizes his financial woes and creative angst, showing him nearly on the verge of a breakdown which is shown when the boy playing Juliet is about to go onstage, and Shakespeare is convinced the entire show will collapse. Joseph Fiennes' acting is seen vividly stressed, adding suspense towards the audience as it seems the door of success is closing with this major last-minute twist. Luckily hope is restored in Shakespeare's eyes once Viola appears. On one hand, this heightened anxiety amps up the drama and humor, giving the audience a more relatable version of Shakespeare who feels the weight of his art. On the other hand, it risks flattening a historical figure who not only endured hardship but also achieved significant success during his lifetime. By focusing so intently on his moments of panic, the film's portrayal might make it seem as though he never had a handle on his craft, which glosses over the nuance of an individual recognized for both his struggles and his triumphs. I am curious about the director's choice of making Fiennes highlight the exaggeration of struggles. Perhaps it would make Shakespeare's eventual achievements feel even more extraordinary. Again, at times I saw myself cringing from the exaggeration but at times I would see myself laughing especially at the same scene when finding a replacement for Juliet.

Another aspect that I disliked was the lack of mentioning Shakespeare's wife, Anne Hathaway. Although she is indirectly mentioned like once the film never properly acknowledges her. As someone interested in how the people closest to Shakespeare influenced his writing, I found this lack of focus puzzling, especially since omitting Anne Hathaway erases an entire dimension of his personal history. Why leave her out when she was so central to his life?

Perhaps the filmmakers wanted to craft a purely romantic fantasy with Viola unchallenged as his muse, letting viewers indulge in the idea of Shakespeare as a passionate dreamer unburdened by existing ties. When Shakespeare is told to be sent back to Stratford to his wife, Anne Hathaway is not directly mentioned but it is assumed it is her since that is his only wife. The actor playing Viola, Gwyneth Paltrow, seemed to be puzzled by that statement just like I was with the film not directly mentioning Hathaway. Paltrow's acting in this scene was portrayed as if she was played which was also seen in Fiennes' eyes which showed the "Oh, I messed up big time" look. Again, I thought the film was going to expand on Viola being angry that Shakespeare was cheating on his wife with her but instead it is ignored when the news that Christopher Marlow is dead. The affair continues and the marriage of Anne Hathaway and William Shakespeare is ignored. In doing so, the film sidesteps a fascinating reality: the tension between his real marriage and the sweeping love story we see on screen. Including that complexity might have deepened our understanding of Shakespeare, showing how art can bloom from a life full of competing loyalties and influences. By ignoring Anne Hathaway, the film keeps the focus tight on its fairy-tale romance, but at the cost of underexploring a chapter that could have added layers to Shakespeare's on-screen persona.

Ultimately, *Shakespeare in Love* depicted how one's experience can influence and create art. The film proposes that despite obstacles and struggles, there's always something in store



Image 1: Shakespeare & Viola portraying as Romeo & Juliet in the finale.

which is seen as Shakespeare could not marry Viola. In

depicting Will and Viola's

affairs in parallel with Romeo

and Juliet, the story suggests

that an author's most personal

experiences can serve as their

greatest inspiration. It also highlights the transformative power of theater itself, where constraints like gender restrictions and political threats give way to shared imagination.

Despite its historical shortcuts, *Shakespeare in Love* mostly succeeds in entertainment, vibrant costumes, and strong ensemble cast. I appreciate how it balances humor with love as the plot develops. And with that, I rate the film as 7.2/10 due to the references of Shakespeare's work, humor, pursuit of love despite its flaws of vagueness and historical inaccuracies.